INNOVATIVE RESEARCH THOUGHTS IN SOCIAL SCIENCES
Peer Review, Refereed, Biannual, Social Science Journal, Open Access Journal
ISSN: 3107-5096(ONLINE)
VOL. 2, ISSUE 3 (SEPTEMBER) 2026

Greenwashing vs. Genuine Sustainability Communication: Consumer Interpretation of Green Advertisements in the Western Himalayan Region

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Citation:
Dogra, V., & Tripathi, C. (2026). Greenwashing vs. Genuine Sustainability Communication: Consumer Interpretation of Green Advertisements in the Western Himalayan Region. Innovation Research Thoughts in Social Sciences, 2(3), 14–21.
DOI:
https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23032960

Abstract

The proliferation of green advertising in consumer markets has intensified concerns about the authenticity of environmental claims, particularly in ecologically sensitive regions where communities maintain strong normative relationships with the environment. This paper examines how young consumers in the Western Himalayan region interpret and respond to green advertisements, distinguishing between genuine sustainability claims and greenwashing. Grounded in an interdisciplinary theoretical framework that integrates the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB), the Greenwashing Perception Framework (GPF), and the Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM), this study investigates the cognitive and affective processes through which young Western Himalayan consumers evaluate the credibility of green advertising claims. Drawing on a mixed-methods research design comprising structured questionnaire surveys and supplemented by interpretive focus group discussions, the study reveals that Western Himalayan consumers possess an ecologically embedded evaluative schema that heightens sensitivity to vague or hyperbolic environmental claims. Perceived greenwashing significantly mediates the relationship between advertising exposure and consumer trust, eroding behavioural intention. The paper concludes by offering region specific implications for sustainability communicators, regulators, and marketers, underscoring that effective green communication in the Western Himalayas must foreground specificity, verifiability, and cultural resonance to transcend greenwashing scepticism.

Keywords: *Greenwashing, Green Advertising, Sustainability Communication, Theory of Planned Behavior, Elaboration Likelihood Model, Western Himalayas, Environmental Scepticism*

Introduction

The global surge in environmental awareness has catalysed a corresponding explosion in green marketing a communications strategy through which organisations highlights their ecological commitments to increasingly discerning consumers. Yet this very proliferation has bred a paradox: as green advertising becomes more widespread, its credibility diminishes. The phenomenon of 'Greenwashing' i.e the practice of making misleading, vague, or unsubstantiated environmental claims has emerged as one of the most consequential trust deficits in the current marketing communication (Delmas & Burbano, 2011). While greenwashing has received substantial scholarly attention in Western, urban, and industrialised consumer contexts, its reception and interpretation among communities in ecologically embedded, geographically peripheral, and culturally distinct regions remains significantly underexplored.

The Western Himalayan region of India encompassing the states of Himachal Pradesh, Uttrakhand and Jammu & Kashmir. Characterised by acute ecological vulnerability, an economy substantially dependent on tourism, agriculture, and horticulture, and a population with historically intimate ties to the nature, this region constitutes a theoretically generative and practically important site for studying green advertising reception. Consumers here are not passive recipients of mainstream marketing messages as they are inhabitants of a landscape increasingly threatened by climate change, unsustainable tourism, and environmental degradation, and their responses to environmental claims are consequently filtered through lived ecological knowledge and heightened normative expectations.

This paper aims to: (1) examine how consumers in the Western Himalayan region cognitively and affectively process green advertisements; (2) identify the conditions under which such advertisements are perceived as credible versus greenwashed; and (3) explore the implications of these interpretive processes for purchase intention and sustainability oriented behaviour. The study addresses a significant gap in the green advertising literature by situating consumer interpretation within a geographically and culturally specific context, thereby challenging the universalising assumptions that pervade much of the existing scholarship.

To achieve these objectives, the paper constructs an interdisciplinary theoretical framework combining three complementary theoretical traditions: the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB; Ajzen, 1991), the Greenwashing Perception Framework (GPF; Chen & Chang, 2013), and the Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM; Petty & Cacioppo, 1986). Together, these frameworks illuminate the motivational, evaluative, and cognitive processing dimensions of green advertising reception. The following sections detail the theoretical scaffolding, methodological design, empirical findings, and their implications for sustainability communication in mountain consumer markets.

2. Theoretical Framework

2.1 Theory of Planned Behavior and Green Advertising

The Theory of Planned Behavior (Ajzen, 1991) proposes that behavioural intention serves as the immediate predictor of actual behaviour. This intention is shaped by three key determinants: attitude toward the behaviour, subjective norms and perceived control behaviour. In the context of green

consumption, TPB has been extensively applied to explain pro environmental purchase intentions (Paul et al., 2016; Yadav & Pathak, 2016).

However, the standard TPB model, derived largely from urban and Western samples, requires contextual adaptation for application in the Western Himalayas. In this region, subjective norms are constituted not merely by peer groups or reference groups in the conventional marketing sense, but by deeply embedded community norms around environmental stewardship what indigenous ecological epistemology describe as a relational ethics with the nature. When green advertisements are perceived as authentic, they may reinforce these existing pro social norms and elevate purchase intention. Conversely, when perceived as greenwashed, they provoke not merely indifference but active norm violation generating negative affect and trust erosion that suppresses behavioural intention. This study therefore anticipates that subjective norms will function as a moderating variable, amplifying the negative effects of perceived greenwashing on purchase intention in this regional context.

2.2 Greenwashing Perception Framework

Chen and Chang (2013) formalised the Greenwashing Perception Framework to capture the consumer experience of encountering misleading environmental claims. Their framework positions greenwashing perception as a cognitive judgment arising from the discrepancy between an organisation's communicated environmental commitments and its observed or inferred actual environmental performance. This perception is operationalised through dimensions including: vagueness of environmental claims, irrelevance of claimed attributes to the product's principal environmental impact, selective disclosure, and exaggerated or unverifiable assertions.

In the Western Himalayan context, the framework requires supplementation with region-specific indicators of greenwashing. Consumers in this region may draw upon local ecological knowledge to evaluate claims for instance, scrutinising whether a brand's claimed environmental initiatives are consistent with observed practices in tourism, packaging, or resource extraction within the region. This paper extends the GPF by introducing 'ecological incongruence' as a regionspecific antecedent of greenwashing perception.

2.3 Elaboration Likelihood Model and Green Advertisement Processing

Petty and Cacioppo's (1986) Elaboration Likelihood Model offers the most finegrained account of how consumers cognitively process green advertisements. The ELM posits two routes to persuasion: the primary route, through which motivated and cognitively capable individuals engage in careful evaluation of message content; and the peripheral route, through which individuals rely on simple heuristics, source attractiveness, emotional cues, and other low-effort signals to form attitudes.

The relevance of ELM to greenwashing research is profound. Genuine sustainability communication, if well-specified and credibly sourced, is amenable to central route processing, enabling consumers to systematically evaluate the substance of environmental claims. Greenwashing, by contrast, typically relies on peripheral cues: lush natural imagery, the colour green, vague terms like 'eco-friendly' or 'sustainable,' and celebrity endorsements without substantive environmental content. The ELM thus provides a mechanism for explaining how greenwashing 'works' psychologically, even when consumers possess the motivation to engage critically: when advertisements lack concrete, verifiable claims, even motivated consumers cannot engage in primary processing and default to peripheral heuristics.

In the Western Himalayan context, consumers' ecological embeddedness may elevate involvement with environmental advertising, increasing the likelihood of primary route processing. This heightened elaboration potential may render Himalayan consumers simultaneously more capable of detecting greenwashing and more susceptible to the cognitive dissonance that follows when they cannot reconcile peripheral cues with substantive claim deficits.

The integrated theoretical model of ELM with TPB and GPF thus provides a comprehensive account of green advertising reception: ELM explains the processing mechanism; GPF specifies the evaluative outcome of that processing (greenwashing perception); and TPB maps the downstream motivational consequences for behaviour.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Design

A mixed-methods research design was adopted to provide both statistical breadth and interpretive depth (Creswell & Plano Clark, 2018). The quantitative strand comprised a structured questionnaire survey administered to young consumers across five muncipal corporations of Himachal Pradesh that are Shimla, Solan, Mandi, Dharamsala, and Palampur. The qualitative strand comprised six focus group discussions (FGDs), each comprising six to eight participants, designed for detailed, context sensitive and elicit interpretation of green advertising narratives.

3.2 Sampling and Data Collection

The survey employed a purposive stratified sampling strategy, stratifying the population by location, age group (18–35 years), and gender to ensure representational adequacy. A total of 350 questionnaires were distributed across the five locations, with 320 returned in usable form (response rate: 91.4%). Survey items were adapted from validated scales: the TPB measurement scales (Ajzen, 1991; Paul et al., 2016),the Greenwashing Perception Scale (Chen & Chang, 2013),and elaboration likelihood indicators adapted from Bhattacherjee and Sanford (2006). Participants were shown four digital green advertisements comprising of different sectors and asked to respond to the scale items thereafter.

Focus group discussions were conducted in both Hindi and English, audio recorded with informed consent, and transcribed and translated verbatim.

3.3 Analytical Methods

Quantitative data were analysed using IBM SPSS Statistics 27. Confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) was conducted to assess the construct validity of the measurement scales, followed by structural equation modelling (SEM) to test the proposed integrated theoretical model.

Mediation analysis was performed to examine whether greenwashing perception mediated the relationship between elaboration (ELM processing route) and green purchase intention. Moderation analysis tested whether subjective norms (TPB) moderated the mediated pathway.

Qualitative data from FGDs were analysed using thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2006), following a hybrid deductive-inductive approach:

initial codes were derived from the theoretical framework, with provision for emergent themes reflecting region-specific discourses not anticipated by existing theory. Member checking and inter-rater reliability assessment (Cohen's kappa = 0.81) ensured analytical rigour.

4. Results and Discussion

4.1 Descriptive Profile and Preliminary Findings

The survey sample comprised 320 respondents (male: 54.1%; female: 45.9%), with a mean age of 24.7 years. Approximately 67% reported exposure to green advertising through digital platforms. A majority (71.6%) reported moderate to high concern about environmental degradation in Himachal Pradesh, and 58.1% indicated that perceptions of environmental authenticity influenced their purchasing decisions to a great extent.

Preliminary item analysis confirmed adequate internal consistency for all scales (Cronbach's alpha ranging from 0.75 to 0.81). CFA results supported the proposed factor structure, with acceptable fit indices (CFI = 0.92; RMSEA = 0.061; SRMR = 0.066), validating the measurement model for subsequent SEM analysis.

4.2 Greenwashing Perception and Advertising Evaluation

Consistent with GPF predictions, respondents demonstrated considerable scepticism toward vague and green claims based merely on images. One of the four advertisements showed, has employed exclusively peripheral cues like scenic Himalayan imagery, the tagline "100% natural," and no third-party certification was rated highest on the greenwashing perception scale (M = 4.31, SD = 0.87), while the advertisement featuring specific environmental claims and certification by a authorised body received the lowest greenwashing perception score (M =1.96, SD = 0.74).

FGD data highly complemented these findings. Participants frequently articulated what we termed as "ecological incongruence", As one participant in the Kullu group has mentioned: "We see the waste, we see the plastic, the residue of the production process. When a company claims that they promote sustainability, we ask: How? We do not just believe on a scenery of a green land or Mountain or picture of a river." This discourse exemplifies the ‘ecological incongruence’ construct introduced in this paper's theoretical framework: greenwashing perception was heightened when advertising imagery invoked the regional environment while making claims that participants could not corroborate through lived experience.

The region-specific dimension of greenwashing perception is particularly notable. Western Himalayan respondents did not merely resort to general advertising scepticism; they applied ecologically specific evaluative criteria derived from environmental proximity and dependency.

4.3 ELM Processing Routes and Elaboration Outcomes

SEM results confirmed the primary ELM proposition that elaboration route was a significant predictor of evaluative outcome. Consumers classified as high involvement processors were significantly more likely to engage in argument based evaluation (central route; $\beta = 0.61$, $p < .001$), and this processing route was associated with more accurate differentiation between credible and non credible green claims. Low involvement consumers, processing via the peripheral route, were more susceptible to accepting vague environmental claims as credible when accompanied by attractive natural imagery ($\beta = 0.47$, $p < .001$ for peripheral route positivity bias).

However, a nuanced finding that extends that among the high involvement Himalayan consumers, even central route processing sometimes yielded

heightened scepticism beyond what claim quality alone would predict. This suggests that the ecological embeddedness of the regional population creates a scepticism amplification effect. This finding has significant implications for advertisers seeking to target the Western Himalayan market that peripheral cue strategies are particularly likely to backfire among environmentally engaged consumers, while even well specified claims may face elevated scrutiny from those with direct environmental knowledge.

4.4 TPB Constructs and Behavioural Intention

SEM results confirmed all three TPB antecedents as significant predictors of green purchase intention. Attitude toward green purchasing ($\beta = 0.38$, $p < .001$), perceived behavioural control ($\beta = 0.29$, $p < .001$), and subjective norms ($\beta = 0.44$, $p < .001$) were all significant, with subjective norms emerging as the strongest single predictor of green purchase intention in this sample, a finding consistent with the theoretical anticipation that normative social influence is especially potent in community oriented, ecologically embedded societies.

Furthermore, greenwashing perception significantly and negatively predicted purchase intention ($\beta = -0.52$, $p < .001$), confirming the mediation hypothesis. indicating that consumers embedded in proenvironmental social networks experienced stronger purchase intention suppression when they detected greenwashing.

FGD output provided contextual support for these findings. Participants described the social consequences of being seen to purchase from brands perceived as greenwashers within their communities is a reputational concern that operated through the subjective norms pathway.

4.5 Genuine Sustainability Communication: Enabling Conditions

An Indian beauty and wellness brand advertised for its natural, and Himalayan rooted formulations rated as most credible. The brand is known for using natural ingredients, responsible sourcing, and strong appeal among consumers seeking authentic, sustainable alternatives offers positive evidence of what constitutes effective sustainability communication in the Western Himalayan context. This advertisement generated the highest green purchase intention scores ($M = 4.04$), lowest greenwashing perception, and highest central route processing engagement across all respondent segments.

Further the analysis of FGD data identified four enabling themes for making credible sustainability communication in western himalyan region, these are specificity, local verifiability, third-party certification, and cultural resonance. These themes represent an empirically grounded communication checklist for practitioners operating in ecologically sensitive himalyan consumer markets.

5. Discussion

The findings of this study make several contributions to the green advertising, sustainability communication, and consumer psychology literatures. Primarly, they state that greenwashing is not a mere scepticism but a market driven cognitive judgment, shaped by the consumer's environmental context, experiential knowledge, and community norms. The 'ecological incongruence' construct introduced in this paper is a theoretically productive extension of the GPF that is likely to hold explanatory value in other environmentally sensitive regions not only in India but worldwide

Second, the study reveals a paradox within ELM's application to green advertising in highly engaged, ecologically conscious and immersed population. The finding of this study suggest that ecological consciousness creates evaluative parameters so stringent that even central route processing may produce heightened scepticism disproportionate to objective claim quality.

The ELM framework generally predicts that high elaboration leads to more accurate attitude formation, this study has contradictory findings suggests that for communities with strong ecological identities, the epistemological bar for credible environmental communication is set higher than conventional marketing practice typically achieves.

Third, the peculiar influence of subjective norms on purchase intention in this sample extends TPB framework applications in an opposite direction. The existing green consumption literature has consistently identified attitude as the strongest TPB antecedent, while this study has a contradictory observation with subjective norms playing a dominant role. This finding has implications beyond the Western Himalayan region, it suggests sustainability messaging for community oriented groups should emphasize social norms and community practices, along with individual attitude change.

6. Conclusion

This paper has examined the interpretation of green advertisements among consumers in the Western Himalayan region, proposing an integrated theoretical framework combining the Theory of Planned Behavior, the Greenwashing Perception Framework, and the Elaboration Likelihood Model. The empirical findings confirm that greenwashing perception is a powerful mediator of the advertising intention relationship, that ecological embeddedness amplifies evaluative scrutiny, and that subjective norms exert unusually strong normative control over green purchase intention in this regional context.

For sustainability communicators and marketers, the study delivers a very clear message that effective green advertising in the Western Himalayas requires specificity, authenticity, institutional certification, along with genuine cultural resonance.

For policymakers and regulators, the study underscores the need for regionally sensitised green advertising standards. India's existing advertising self regulatory frameworks address some dimensions of greenwashing but lack the regional specificity needed to address the ecological incongruence dynamic identified in this study.

Here we also need to acknowledge the limitations of the study. Firstly, while the sample is geographically stratified, but still confined to urban and semi urban population and may not fully capture the perspectives of rural, tribal, or nomadic populations in the Western Himalayas. Secondly the use of researcher selected advertisements, while methodologically controlled, but still prone to stimulus specific biases.

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